

THE SABOTEUR™



TIME TO SABOTAGE

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The *Saboteur* is a World War II game. But before you dismiss this as another generic Nazi-killing first-person shooter, let me tell you that it isn't. Yes, you do kill Nazis in *The Saboteur*, but this isn't a war game. It's a story of personal vengeance that just happens to take place during World War II in Nazi-controlled Paris. *The Saboteur* is a free-roaming action adventure game with a mission structure similar to that of *Grand Theft Auto*. In fact, it borrows ideas from many popular games. But does it manage to create an identity of its own?

You play as foul-mouthed Irish race car driver Sean Devlin, who is forced to flee to Paris after the war breaks out. There he finds himself on a personal quest to avenge the death of his best friend at the hands of a top Gustapo agent. Somewhere along the way, he gets caught up in the Parisian resistance movement and simultaneously chain-smokes his way towards ridding Paris of the Nazis.

The *Saboteur* is an open world game and the missions are mostly of the infiltrate, kill and destroy variety. There is also a fair amount of *Assassin's Creed*-style platforming and Sean is able to climb pretty much any building in the city. Missions can be dealt with in multiple ways. You can either go all guns blazing or throw on a Nazi uniform and see how far the stealthy approach takes you. Gun play is satisfactorily

exciting without being perfect, while the Hitman-inspired stealth works well enough without being as clinical as specialist stealth titles.

The most unique aspect of *The Saboteur* is its art style. Nazi-controlled areas are ominously dark, gloomy and devoid of all colour, with only the yellow tinge of window panes at night and red representing Nazi flags, arm bands and control points breaking the monotony of black and white. When it's pouring down, it is reminiscent of Frank Miller's *Sin City*, and along with a fantastic '60s soundtrack, it creates a brilliant atmosphere. But liberate these areas by completing missions and the look is drastically different. It's vivid and colourful like a Disney animated film and it's almost jarring to a point where you'll start to miss the noir film charm of the Nazi areas.

Besides the story missions, which vary from chase sequences in giant zeppelins and car races to assassinations and destroying Nazi control points, you also have side missions. These consist of destroying smaller Nazi installments such as sniper towers, radars, AA guns and propaganda speakers. Completing missions earns you contraband, which you can use at various dealers to buy weapons and ammo. There is also an interesting perk system that rewards you for excelling in various areas such as gunplay, sniping, stealth kills and driving.

As we said, missions are presented in the standard GTA-esque 'go there and talk to him' structure, platforming is strikingly similar to

Assassin's Creed, stealth is inspired by Hitman, and the area liberation system is similar to, most recently, *Infamous*. So clearly, *The Saboteur* is a game built on borrowed ideas, and while that may sound bad on paper, the implementation of these elements, while not perfect, is pretty good and they come together cohesively to provide a fair amount of gameplay variety.

The Saboteur isn't historically accurate, the voice acting is so bad that it almost feels intentional. What it lacks in polish and production values, it makes up by delivering heaps of simple, unadulterated fun. And that's worth something. **d**

THE SABOTEUR

7/10

Developer: Pandemic Studios

Publisher: EA

Genre: Action-adventure

Platforms: PS3 (Rs 2,499), Xbox 360 (Rs 1,899), PC (Rs 999)

PC MINIMUM REQUIREMENTS

Operating system:

Win XP SP3, Vista SP1, Win 7

CPU:

Intel Core2Duo 2.4 Ghz or AMD equivalent

RAM: 2 GB

HDD: 7 GB

Video: NVIDIA GeForce 7800GTX w/ 256MB video ram or ATI Radeon HD2600 Pro

Sound: DirectX 9c compliant sound